CENTER FOR COMPETITIVE STATECRAFT AND STRATEGIC POLICY

WP-2026 SERIES

STYLE AND VERBIAGE GUIDE

Format · Structure · Institutional Voice · Analytic Tradecraft · Production Standards

Version	3.0 — Unified Edition (Style Guide v2.0 + BW Assessment Verbiage Guide integrated)
Date	March 2026
Supersedes	Style Guide v1.0 (March 2026), Style Guide v2.0 (March 2026)
Authority	ODNI Analytic Standards · CIA Structured Analysis Tradecraft · WP-2026 Series Conventions
Applies To	All WP-2026 series papers, revisions, and new companion documents
Purpose	Govern word choice, sentence structure, document architecture, visual design, and analytic voice across the full series. Apply to every substantive paragraph.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide has three integrated components:

- Part 1: Institutional Voice Standard — the governing principles of the analytic register, sentence structure, and prohibited language.
- Part 2: Analytic Tradecraft — the ODNI-anchored verbiage standard: approved verbs, probability/confidence axes, approved phrases, and conversion table.
- Part 3: Document Architecture and Production Standards — structure, visual design, block types, source tiers, and revision checklist.

PART 1: INSTITUTIONAL VOICE STANDARD

The WP-2026 series targets a specific register: institutionally coherent analysis that reads as credible across government, academic, and professional policy audiences simultaneously. It does not imitate any specific institution. It demonstrates through precision, structure, and economy of language that the author operates at the analytical altitude of serious institutional producers. The register is boring by design. Boring is the signal.

1. The Five Governing Principles

> **PRINCIPLE 1 — PRECISION OVER ELEGANCE**
>
> Every word carries a specific denotation. Synonyms are not substituted for variety. If 'designation' is the correct term, it appears every time. Technical vocabulary, once introduced, is used consistently. The prose is not varied. It is exact.

> **PRINCIPLE 2 — ECONOMY OVER COMPREHENSIVENESS**
>
> The analytical point is the first sentence of every section and paragraph. No throat-clearing. No 'this section will examine.' No 'it is worth noting that.' If it is worth noting, note it. The structure delivers what the reader needs to know in the order they need to know it.

> **PRINCIPLE 3 — STRUCTURE CARRIES EPISTEMIC WEIGHT**
>
> Uncertainty is expressed through labeled confidence levels, not through hedging language. 'This may suggest' and 'it seems possible that' are prohibited. The confidence label MODERATE CONFIDENCE or ANALYTICALLY INFERRED carries the epistemological weight so the declarative sentence does not have to.

> **PRINCIPLE 4 — AGENT SPECIFICITY**
>
> Every action has an agent, an authority, and a date. 'OFAC designated X under EO 14024 on October 22, 2025' — not 'X was designated.' Passive voice is prohibited except for institutional attribution. The passive voice that obscures who acted is the enemy of analytic accountability.

> **PRINCIPLE 5 — NUMBERS ARE SPECIFIC AND SOURCED, OR THEY DO NOT APPEAR**
>
> 'Approximately 35% of Chinese crude supply transits Hormuz [Vortexa, March 2026]' — not 'a significant share.' 'Significant,' 'substantial,' 'considerable,' and 'large' are prohibited as substitutes for specific figures.

2. Core Drafting Rule

Every substantive paragraph answers four questions in this order. A paragraph that cannot answer all four is incomplete.

QUESTION	FUNCTION	MARKER IN TEXT
What is officially reported?	Name the source directly. Attribute factual claims to the specific reporting body.	States · Reports · Assesses · Identifies · Indicates
What is assessed from that reporting?	State your synthesis with a probability and confidence tag.	We assess with [confidence] that [subject] is [probability] to…
What remains unknown?	State what the record does not establish. Always explicit.	The public record does not establish… · The available reporting does not permit…
How confident, and why?	Confidence tag based on source quality and evidence completeness — not on how alarming the finding is.	[HIGH / MODERATE / LOW CONFIDENCE] — defined basis stated

3. The Three-Part Sentence Structure

Apply this structure to every substantive analytic claim. Attribution names the source. Judgment synthesizes with a confidence tag. Limits state what the record does not establish. All three parts are mandatory.

1 ATTRIBUTION	ODNI's 2025 Annual Threat Assessment assesses that Russia maintains an offensive CBW program inconsistent with its BWC obligations and that its threat is expanding.
2 JUDGMENT	These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that Russia is likely to continue developing capabilities relevant to biological and chemical warfare; the official record is consistent with an active program posture.
3 LIMITS	However, the public record does not establish operational scope, specific employment thresholds, or the current deployment status of any particular agent or delivery system.

Three-part structure applied to a Russia CBW claim. Attribution (Step 1) names the ODNI ATA directly. Judgment (Step 2) synthesizes with explicit probability and confidence labels. Limits (Step 3) states precisely what the record does not establish.

PART 2: ANALYTIC TRADECRAFT

Anchored to ODNI Analytic Standards and CIA structured analysis tradecraft guidance. Apply throughout all papers in the series.

4. Probability and Confidence Axes

Probability and confidence are separate dimensions. Both must be applied separately to every analytic judgment. Probability describes the likelihood that the judgment is correct. Confidence describes the quality and completeness of the supporting evidence. A judgment can be high-probability but low-confidence — or vice versa.

PROBABILITY SCALE — USE IN JUDGMENT LANGUAGE	CONFIDENCE TAGS — USE AS LABELED QUALIFIERS
Almost certainly	HIGH CONFIDENCE — Directly supported by official, repeated, consistent authoritative reporting.
Very likely	MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Supported by official reporting with gaps, ambiguity, or mixed sourcing.
Likely · Probably	LOW CONFIDENCE — Plausible inference; not established in official public reporting.
Roughly even odds	LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Thin but structurally sound inference.
Unlikely	MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE — Strong sourcing with limited acknowledged inference.
Very unlikely	
Almost certainly not	

COMBINED USAGE EXAMPLE

"We assess with moderate confidence that Iran is likely to continue pursuing capabilities relevant to offensive biological risk, based on ODNI reporting indicating ongoing CBW-relevant R&D. The public record does not establish the operational scope or current weaponization status of any identified program."

Probability: likely — Confidence: moderate — Limits stated explicitly.

5. Approved Verb Taxonomy

Use the correct verb category for the correct function. Attribution verbs are for stating what a source reports. Synthesis verbs are for stating your analytic judgment derived from that reporting. Mixing the categories signals analytic imprecision.

ATTRIBUTION VERBS — WHAT A SOURCE REPORTS	SYNTHESIS VERBS — YOUR ANALYTIC JUDGMENT
states · reports · assesses · judges	suggests · supports the judgment that

indicates · notes · identifies describes · finds · raises concern about documents · characterizes · acknowledges	is consistent with · appears to indicate points to · is best understood as warrants concern · supports a [confidence] judgment that raises the inference that · is assessed as

6. Approved Analytic Phrases

FOR ESTABLISHING THE EVIDENCE BASE	FOR NAMING GAPS AND LIMITS
the public record supports official reporting indicates the available evidence suggests for defensive planning purposes the strongest defensible judgment is on balance · in aggregate the most policy-relevant implication is documented open-source reporting indicates the available evidence is consistent with	the open-source picture remains incomplete this assessment does not establish the evidentiary basis varies by subject the available reporting does not permit a firm conclusion intelligence gaps remain the principal uncertainty concerns in the public record the public record does not permit this paper does not assess beyond

7. Weak-to-Strong Conversion Table

Apply this table during revision. For every claim that appears in a weaker form, substitute the stronger form. The stronger form states the same analytical content with appropriate attribution and explicit limits.

WEAKER PHRASING — Avoid	STRONGER PHRASING — Use
China is clearly running a covert biological program.	Public reporting raises compliance and capability concerns regarding China; the open-source record does not establish the scope of any current prohibited program.
Russia definitely intends to use these capabilities.	Official U.S. reporting identifies an expanding Russian CBW threat; the public record does not permit a firm conclusion about specific employment thresholds.
Iran is secretly preparing biological attacks.	ODNI reporting indicates offensive-purpose concern related to Iranian CBW R&D; the public record remains limited on operational scope.
North Korea is an apocalyptic biological threat.	North Korea presents a persistent unconventional WMD risk, including biological-warfare-related

WEAKER PHRASING — Avoid	STRONGER PHRASING — Use
	concern in official U.S. reporting.
China and Russia are winning the trade war.	Official reporting and commercial data indicate expanding China-Russia energy and mineral trade volumes; assessed impact on US enforcement effectiveness remains a principal uncertainty.
The corridor is clearly under US control.	Under the scenario premise, the US-led coalition has established contested maritime security operations in the Hormuz corridor; sustained control is scenario-conditioned and not assessed as achieved.
This proves that Iran violated the BWC.	Available reporting is consistent with treaty non-compliance concerns; the public record does not establish the evidentiary standard required for a formal treaty violation determination.
The BRI is a debt trap designed to seize assets.	Chinese state lending structures in BRI agreements have created contingent coercive leverage over sovereign infrastructure in documented cases; whether this reflects deliberate design intent is analytically contested.

8. Prohibited Language: Three Categories

All three categories are prohibited in every paper. They signal different failures: prosecutorial certainty signals advocacy, emotive inflation signals poor discipline, and advocacy language signals the analysis has a conclusion it is trying to produce rather than derive.

PROSECUTORIAL CERTAINTY	EMOTIVE INFLATION	ADVOCACY LANGUAGE
proves · demonstrates conclusively confirms beyond doubt · exposes reveals the truth · undeniably clearly · without question definitively establishes	terrifying · horrific · sinister apocalyptic · nightmare scenario catastrophic (undefined consequence) evil · evil regime · rogue state unprecedented threat	the world must · no choice but urgent moral necessity immediate decisive action required everyone knows · it is obvious must act now · cannot wait

Extended prohibited pattern list — applies across all papers:

PROHIBITED PATTERN	REPLACE WITH
It should be noted that...	State the point directly. Delete the frame.

PROHIBITED PATTERN	REPLACE WITH
This paper argues that... / This section will...	State the argument. The structure announces it.
Clearly / Obviously / Of course	If it requires saying, say it without the modifier.
It is important to... / It is worth noting...	The structure demonstrates importance. Do not assert it.
May suggest / Could indicate / Seems to imply	ASSESSED WITH [CONFIDENCE]: [declarative claim]
A significant / substantial / large share	Specific figure with Tier 1/2 source citation, or omit.
This analysis seeks to... / We attempt to...	State what the analysis does, not what it seeks to do.
X was designated (agent obscured)	OFAC designated X under [authority] on [date].
Going forward / Moving ahead	On [timeline]: [specific projection with confidence label].
Interestingly / Notably / Importantly	Delete. The analysis makes it notable by including it.
This is a complex issue / nuanced problem	Complexity is shown through the analysis, not named.
Many analysts believe / experts agree	Cite specific analysts with institutional attribution.

PART 3: DOCUMENT ARCHITECTURE AND PRODUCTION STANDARDS

9. Standard Document Architecture

9.1 Mandatory Page Structure (in order)

1. Cover metadata table
2. Classification and NOTICE block
3. Methodological note (scenario premise, confidence lexicon, documented/modeled boundary convention)
4. Key Judgments (3–7 numbered declarative sentences with probability and confidence labels)
5. Numbered Parts with decimal-numbered sections
6. Sources and reference basis (tiered)
7. Footnotes
8. End of document line

9.2 Key Judgments: Mandatory Rules

KEY JUDGMENTS FORMAT

- 3 to 7 judgments per paper.
- Each judgment is one declarative sentence. No subordinate clauses introducing new analytical content.
- Each judgment carries both a probability word (likely, very likely, almost certainly) AND a confidence tag (MODERATE CONFIDENCE, HIGH CONFIDENCE, etc.).
- Judgments are numbered. The number signals priority ordering.
- SCENARIO-CONDITIONED judgments carry that label in addition to their confidence level.

Example Key Judgment block format:

1 **MODERATE CONFIDENCE · SCENARIO-CONDITIONED**

The March 2026 Hormuz crisis is assessed with moderate confidence to have opened a five-to-ten year window during which a US-led coalition can likely convert corridor control into durable structural advantage over China and Russia through concurrent execution of the four components analyzed in this paper.

2 **MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED**

China's Hormuz vulnerability is very likely declining structurally as electrification reduces fossil fuel's share of total energy consumption; the leverage window is assessed with moderate confidence to require institutional lock-in within the stated

> timeline before that structural shift reduces the coercive utility of corridor control.

9.3 Section Header Convention

PROHIBITED — Argumentative	CORRECT — Descriptive / Functional
Why This Crisis Is About More Than Iran	Strategic Context and Assessment Scope
The Corridor Architecture That Was Supposed to Be Permanent	Pre-Crisis China-Russia Economic Architecture
How the US and Partners Gain While Russia and China Lose	Positive-Sum Coalition Architecture: Component Analysis
India — The Swing Variable	India: Strategic Posture and Coalition Design Implications
The Honest Limits	Structural Constraints and Confidence Boundaries
What They're Really Doing	Observed / Officially Reported
How Dangerous They Really Are	Strategic Significance
What Must Be Done	Implications for U.S. and Allied Policy

9.4 Preferred Section Labels for Assessment Papers

USE — Institutional, Analytic	AVOID — Rhetorical
Observed / Officially Reported	What They're Really Doing
Assessment	The Truth
Strategic Significance	How Dangerous They Really Are
Unknowns / Intelligence Gaps	Hidden Program
Implications for U.S. and Allied Policy	What Must Be Done
Limitations of the Public Record	(No rhetorical counterpart — always include this section)
Analytic Confidence and Evidentiary Basis	How Sure We Are
Scenario Premise and Scope	What We're Assuming

10. Visual Design System

Restraint is the design principle. Navy does the structural work. Everything else is neutral. No decorative color. No gradient. The document looks like a serious institution produced it because serious institutions do not decorate their analytical products.

10.1 Color Palette

ROLE	HEX	NAME	APPLICATION
Primary	1B2A4A	Deep Navy	All headings, table header fills, cover elements, divider lines, KJ number blocks
Secondary	2E4172	Navy Mid	Box label secondary accent — use sparingly
Body Secondary	4A5568	Slate Gray	Footnote text, captions, header/footer, secondary labels
Accent	8B6914	Antique Gold	Confidence labels in KJ blocks ONLY — nowhere else
Table Alt Row	E8EDF5	Light Navy	Alternating table rows, accent box fills, KJ background
Page Warm	FAFAFA	Warm White	Alternating table rows (light), default page background
Warning Fill	FEF3E2	Amber Warm	Implementation Friction boxes, caveat boxes, Limits step in 3-part structure
Confirmed Fill	EAF4EC	Sage Green	Documented Structural Constraint boxes only
Prohibited Fill	FDECEC	Muted Red	Prohibited language tables, critical failure indicators

10.2 Box Types and Left-Border Convention

All analytical boxes use a left-border accent only — no full border frame. This signals a labeled analytical insert without the visual weight of a full box. Full-border tables are reserved for data tables only.

BOX TYPE	LEFT BORDER COLOR	FILL	USE FOR
Accent Box (default)	Deep Navy 1B2A4A	Light Navy E8EDF5	Key Judgments, Scenario Premise, Analytic Posture, Core Judgment, Series Position, Principle statements
Warm Box	Amber 7A4000	Amber Warm FEF3E2	Implementation Friction, caveat, political constraint,

BOX TYPE	LEFT BORDER COLOR	FILL	USE FOR
			execution risk, Limits step
Green Box	Dark Green 1A5C2E	Sage Green EAF4EC	Documented Structural Constraint — empirical anchor, NOT scenario-conditioned
Notice Box	Amber 7A4000	Amber Warm FEF3E2	Document-level notice block — cover page only

10.3 Typography

ELEMENT	FONT	SIZE (pt)	WEIGHT	COLOR
Body text	Arial	11	Regular	Black #000000
H1 Part heading	Arial	15	Bold	Deep Navy 1B2A4A
H2 Section heading	Arial	12	Bold	Deep Navy 1B2A4A
H3 Subsection	Arial	11	Bold	Slate Gray 4A5568
Table header text	Arial	10	Bold	White on Navy fill
Table body text	Arial	10	Regular	Black #000000
Box label	Arial	10	Bold + AllCaps	Navy or contextual per box type
Box body text	Arial	10	Regular	Black #000000
Footnotes / captions	Arial	9	Regular + Italic	Slate Gray 4A5568
Header / Footer	Arial	8	Regular + AllCaps	Slate Gray 4A5568
KJ confidence label	Arial	9	Bold + AllCaps	Antique Gold 8B6914
KJ number	Arial	14	Bold	White on Navy block
Three-part step labels	Arial	9	Bold	White on Navy/Navy Mid/Slate

11. Source Tier System

Source tier is cited at point of use, not only in the bibliography. Confidence labels are calibrated against the tier of supporting evidence. Never assert HIGH CONFIDENCE on a Tier 2 or Tier 3 source alone.

TIER	SOURCE TYPES	SUPPORTS	CITATION FORMAT
Tier 1	US Government (EIA, OFAC, DoD, CRS, ODNI ATA, State Dept compliance reports); UN bodies (IAEA, UNODA, UNSCR); primary legal texts; peer-reviewed journals	HIGH CONFIDENCE or MODERATE CONFIDENCE	[TIER 1 — ODNI ATA 2025, p. 14]
Tier 2	CSIS, RAND, Carnegie, Brookings, Atlantic Council, AidData, SIPRI; IEA WEO, BP Statistical Review, Vortexa, BNEF; Foreign Affairs, TNSR, Survival; congressional testimony with named attribution	MODERATE CONFIDENCE	[TIER 2 — Vortexa, March 2026]
Tier 3	Major news media with named institutional sources; trade publications with specific data; think tank blogs	LOW CONFIDENCE / Contextual only	[TIER 3 — Reuters, March 5, 2026 — contextual only]
PROHIBITED	Wikipedia; scenario-constructed entries; anonymous sources; circular sourcing; sources that are products of the same analytical exercise	Never cite	Remove without replacement

12. Confidence Lexicon (Full Reference)

TERM	DEFINITION	PAIRED WITH PROBABILITY
HIGH CONFIDENCE	Claim directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 sources with consistent findings. Analytic inference minimal. Reserve for empirically grounded factual claims only.	almost certainly · very likely
MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE	Strong Tier 1/2 sourcing with limited but acknowledged inference.	very likely · likely
MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Credible Tier 1/2 sourcing with meaningful analytic inference or a significant unresolved variable.	likely · probably · roughly even odds
LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Thin but structurally sound inference from indirect evidence.	unlikely · roughly even odds
LOW CONFIDENCE	Primarily analytic inference from limited or indirect evidence. Reasonable alternative conclusions exist. Does not mean the claim is wrong.	unlikely · very unlikely
SCENARIO-CONDITIONED	Claim valid only under stated scenario premises. Not a prediction.	any probability label — add to confidence label
ANALYTICALLY INFERRED	Derived by logical extension from documented premises. Not directly observed.	any probability label — add to confidence label

13. Series Architecture Reference

PAPER	ROLE	UPSTREAM	READS INTO
ATTRIBUTION-01	Methodology foundation — 4-level nexus framework	None	All papers
CSE-01 / NEXUS-01	PRC nexus extension — 5-rung ladder	ATTRIBUTION-01	SHIELD-01, PERSIST-01, BRI-01/02
PERSIST-01	Strategic architecture — 5-pillar framework	ATTRIBUTION-01, CSE-01	ANCHOR, CONTAIN-01, MAXPRESS-01
TARIFF-01 / ANCHOR	Litigation-resilient tariff enforcement	PERSIST-01	CONTAIN-01, MAXPRESS-01
CONTAIN-01	Long-term sanctions containment doctrine	PERSIST-01, ANCHOR	MAXPRESS-01
MAXPRESS-01	Execution layer — practitioner-ready	CONTAIN-01, PERSIST-01	All enforcement papers
SHIELD-01	PRC-facilitated enforcement + CCRP	CSE-01, PERSIST-01	SENI-01, MAXPRESS-01
SENI-01 (Master Index)	327-node targeting matrix	SHIELD-01, MAXPRESS-01	BRI-01, all enforcement
INFRA-01	Infrastructure enforcement framework	MAXPRESS-01	BRI-01, BRI-02
HORMUZ-01	Regional posture assessment	MAXPRESS-01	HORMUZ-02
HORMUZ-02	Integrated campaign architecture	HORMUZ-01, MAXPRESS-01	BRI-01
BRI-01	Grand strategy capstone	SENI-01, HORMUZ-02, PERSIST-01	BRI-02
BRI-02 (forthcoming)	NEXUS-01 applied to BRI port concessions	CSE-01, SENI-01, INFRA-01	BRI-01
IRAN NUCLEAR	Post-strike nuclear assessment	HORMUZ-01	HORMUZ-02, CPF-02
BW ASSESSMENT	State BW threat assessment	IRAN NUCLEAR	CPF-02
CI ASSESSMENT	Counterintelligence exposure review	All papers	Repository management

14. Pre-Publication Revision Checklist

Apply in order before any submission. Steps 1–8 are required for SSRN. All steps required for peer-reviewed journal or think tank submission.

9. Cover metadata table complete — all mandatory fields present
10. Classification and NOTICE block present with standard text
11. SCENARIO PREMISE block present if paper uses constructed events — positioned at top of Part I before Section 1.1
12. Key Judgments block present — 3–7 numbered judgments, each with probability word AND confidence tag
13. All section headers descriptive/functional — no argumentative headers
14. Confidence lexicon defined in Methodological Note
15. All forward-looking claims labeled SCENARIO-CONDITIONED or ANALYTICALLY INFERRED
16. Three-part sentence structure applied to all substantive analytic claims (Attribution → Judgment → Limits)
17. No Wikipedia citations
18. No trade publications as primary source for consequential quantitative claims
19. All quantitative claims footnoted — specific Tier 1/2 source, date, page or section
20. No prohibited language patterns (see Section 8 tables)
21. No emotive inflation, prosecutorial certainty, or advocacy language
22. Agent-specific construction throughout — every action has an agent, authority, and date
23. IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION box present for every mechanism with a hard execution constraint
24. Limitations of the Public Record section present in all assessment papers
25. BRI-02 cross-reference present in series position metadata where tier classifications used
26. Literature footnotes present for all major analytical claims
27. END OF DOCUMENT line present
28. Page size explicitly US Letter (12240 x 15840 DXA) in production script
29. All table columnWidths sum exactly to table width
30. No ShadingType.SOLID — always ShadingType.CLEAR
31. No Unicode bullet characters in TextRun — always LevelFormat.BULLET

END OF DOCUMENT — WP-2026 STYLE AND VERBIAGE GUIDE v3.0 — MARCH 2026 — UNCLASSIFIED // OPEN SOURCE